thought that he had already warned him once and saw no benefit in doing so again.[22]

The blockade option did not pass. Not only Robert Kennedy but also Bundy, who was usually supportive of McNamara, questioned how the blockade would be implemented and whether one would have to shoot to stop a Soviet ship if the captain refused to submit it to inspection. McNamara was for shooting. This looked like a delayed military action that would be aimed not only against missiles but also against Soviet ships in international waters. McNamara continued to argue his case. His solution was surveillance of the island and a naval blockade to prevent the arrival of any new offensive weapons, as well as the threat of an attack not on Cuba but on the Soviet Union itself if preparations were made to launch the missiles.

McNamara's attempt to gain supporters failed. "I do not think there is a military problem there," argued the secretary of defense. As Bundy expressed his agreement with that statement, McNamara continued: "This is a domestic political problem. In the announcement we did not say we'd go in and not [that] we'd kill them. We said we'd act." He was referring to the statement issued by Kennedy on September 4 and presented the introduction of the blockade as an action promised by the statement. General Carter of the CIA was among the skeptics: "Well, as far as the American people are concerned, action means military action, period." "Well, we have a blockade," responded McNamara. "Search and removal of offensive weapons entering Cuba." Carter was not impressed. "I think it's an alternative," he told McNamara, keeping the blockade apart from the military action but signaling his readiness to consider it. "I think it's a perfect solution by many means," replied the adamant McNamara.[23]

Kennedy held fast to his original idea of ordering a strike against the missile sites but still had some time to arrive at a final decision. A surgical strike was a military solution to his political problem. "[T]his is a political struggle as much as military," he told his advisers that evening. He agreed with McNamara that the missiles did not change the military balance, but politically he felt himself in a bind. "Last month I said we were not going 'to allow it.' Last month I should have said we don't care. But when we said we're *not* going to, and then they go ahead and do it, and then we do